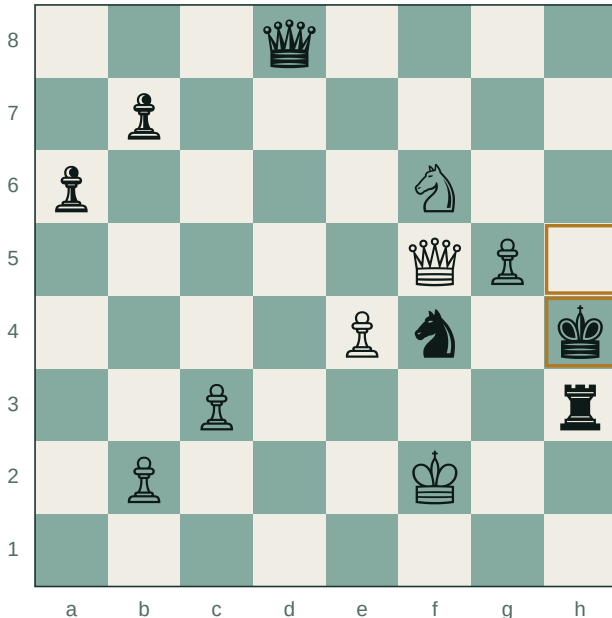


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 41

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 40...Kh4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

41. Qxf4#

41.Qxf4# Mate: queen on f4 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on h4. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Queen on f4. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on h4. Geometrically undefended: queen on d8 and knight on f4. Check for tactical protection.